

**UNIT
12**

MODAL VERBS

**(CAN, COULD, SHALL, SHOULD
MAY, MIGHT, WOULD, MUST)**

UNIT 12 MODAL VERBS

A **modal** is a special verb we use to express **ability, permission, obligation (=duty), and similar expressions**. We can't use two modal verbs one after another in a sentence. We can also call them "Defective verbs" as they don't have their third forms.

• Modal Verbs: "Can" and "Could" for Expressing Ability

1) "Can" is used to express ability in the present or future. It indicates that someone is able to do something right now or generally.

• Examples:

- **Present ability:** "I can speak three languages."
- **Future ability:** "I can finish the project by tomorrow."

2) "Could" is the past form of "can," and it is used to express ability in the past.

• Examples:

- **Past ability:** "When I was younger, I could run faster."
- **Polite requests:** "Could you please pass me the salt?"

• Explanation with Examples:

1) Can

Used for actions you **are able to do** now, or actions you do **regularly**.

- **Examples:** "I **can** swim."

2) Could

Used for actions that you **were able to do** in the past.

- **Example:** "I **could** swim when I was 10 years old."

EXERCISES

Exercise: 1

Fill in the blanks with "can" or "could".

- 1) When I was a child, I _____ climb trees easily.
- 2) I _____ play the piano very well.
- 3) She _____ help you if you ask her.
- 4) When we were in school, we _____ finish all our homework in class.
- 5) _____ you help me with my bags, please?
- 6) I _____ go to the movies tonight if I finish my homework.
- 7) My grandmother _____ cook amazing meals when she was younger.

Exercise: 2

Choose the correct option (Can or Could).

- 1) I _____ speak French when I was a teenager.

a **Can** b **Could**
- 2) I _____ go to the party tomorrow if I finish my work.

a **Can** b **Could**
- 3) _____ you please help me with this homework?

a **Can** b **Could**

4) He _____ ride a bike when he was five.

a Can

b Could

5) She _____ walk very fast.

a Can

b Could

Exercise: 3

Correct the sentences if necessary.

1) I can run a marathon when I was 18.

2) Could you fixing the computer?

3) She can play the violin when she was younger.

4) I could speak English fluently when I was a child.

5) He can to drive very well.

Modal Verbs to Show Permission: Present and Past

Modal verbs are commonly used to ask for, **giving**, and **refusing permission** in both the present and past. Let's break down how modal verbs like **can**, **could**, **may**, **might**, are used to express permission in different ways.

1) Asking for Permission (Present and Past)

- **Present:**

- **Can:**

Used to ask for permission in informal situations.

Example: Can I go to the restroom?

- **May:**

May is more formal and polite than "can,".

Example: May I leave early today?

- **Past:**

- **Could:**

Used to describe permissions we had to things in the past. It is also more polite than "**can**."

Example: I could use your phone yesterday.

- **Might:**

We use might when the speaker feels hesitation to ask for permission.

Example: Might I borrow your car this evening?

2) Giving Permission (Present and Past)

- **Present:**

- **Can:**

Used to give permission in informal situations.

Example: You can take the day off tomorrow.

- **May:**

More formal than "can," used to give permission in polite or formal contexts.

Example: You **may** leave once the meeting is over.

- **Past:**

- **Could:**

Used to give permission in the past. It sounds polite and less direct than "can."

Example: You **could** use my laptop yesterday.

3. Refusing Permission (Present and Past)

- **Present:**

- **Can not (Can't):**

Used to refuse permission in informal contexts.

Example: You **can't** go to the party tonight.

- **May not (mayn't):**

More formal than "can't," used to refuse permission in polite settings.

Example: You **may not** leave the class early.

- **Past:**

- **Couldn't:**

Used to refuse permission in the past for one occasion. It is more polite than "can't."

Example: You **couldn't** take the car last night.

Examples and Explanation:

- **Present Examples:**

- **Asking for Permission:**

Can I leave early today? (informal)

May I use your computer? (formal and polite)

- **Giving Permission:**

You can go to the event. (informal, more relaxed permission)

You may go now. (formal, more official permission)

- **Refusing Permission:**

You can't take the day off. (informal, direct refusal)

You may not use my pen. (polite refusal)

- **Past Examples:**

- **Could (for general permission in the past):**

Could is used for general permission, things one was permitted to do at any point of time in the past.

- **Examples:**

- When I was a child, I could visit the park anytime.
- She could stay out late during summer vacations.
- When I was a child, I couldn't go to the park alone.
- We couldn't watch TV after 9 PM.
- Could you stay up late when you were a child?
- Could they use the library anytime they wanted?

- **Was/Were allowed to (permission in one particular occasion):**

Was/were allowed to is used for one particular occasion in which somebody had the permission to do something.

- **Examples:**

- Yesterday, I was allowed to leave school early.
- They were allowed to attend the concert last weekend.
- I wasn't allowed to leave school early last Monday.
- They weren't allowed to bring mobile phones to the event.
- Were you allowed to leave school early yesterday?
- Was she allowed to enter the restricted area?

EXERCISES

Exercise: 1

Fill in the blanks with the correct Modal Verb.

- 1) _____ I use your phone for a minute? (permission)
- 2) You _____ leave the office now. (giving permission)
- 3) She _____ borrow your notes last time you were away.
(permission)
- 4) You _____ bring any food into the library. (refuse)
- 5) _____ I go to the cinema tomorrow night? (polite inquiry)
- 6) You _____ leave the building once the fire alarm goes off.
(refuse)
- 7) _____ I use your laptop in the next class? (polite inquiry)

Exercise: 2

Choose the correct Modal Verb.

- 1) You _____ go to the concert last week. (could / can / might)
- 2) _____ I borrow your umbrella for a minute? (Could / Can / May)
- 3) You _____ take a break now. (may / can't / might)
- 4) He _____ have asked for permission. (might / could / can't)
- 5) _____ I come in now? (Might / Can / May)

6) You _____ leave after the meeting is over. (can't / might / may)

7) You _____ eat in the classroom. (may not / might not / can't)

Modal Verbs to Show Obligation and Advice in Present

In English, **modal verbs** are used to express **obligation** (things that are necessary to do) and **advice** (the best or the right thing to do in a situation).

1) Should (for advice or mild obligation)

- **Meaning: Should** is used for giving advice, suggesting the best action.

- **Example:**

You **should** drink water every day.

He **should** study for the test to do well.

We **should** eat healthy food.

Exercise: 1

There are mistakes in these sentences. Find and correct them.

1) You should to study for your test.

2) We should forget to bring our books tomorrow.

3) Should I going to the party tonight?

4) He shouldn't playing in the rain.

5) You should watched TV after homework.

6) Should we to walk on the grass?

7) Should we to help our neighbours with their groceries?

8) They shouldn't going to bed late.

9) What should to we do now?

10) How should I will solve my problem?
